Cynefin® Sense-Making

Sort situations by how predictable they are, then choose an approach that fits: analyse, experiment, act or follow the rule.

Lead the Organisation · Inspired by the Cynefin® Framework (Dave Snowden) · Sense-Making · Choose Your Approach

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

TOPIC: Substitutes

DATE: 12 May

1 Complex

PROBE · SENSE · RESPOND

Cause and effect only make sense afterwards.
Run safe-to-fail experiments; amplify what works.

Practice: emergent

- Will families keep a subscription?
- Which substitutes will customers accept?
- Why do customers drift away?

2 Complicated

SENSE · ANALYSE · RESPOND

Cause and effect can be found with analysis or expertise. Ask the experts and weigh options.

Practice: good practice (more than one right answer)

- Speed up the basket API
- Repeat billing with the payment provider
- Forecast the release date

3 Chaotic

ACT · SENSE · RESPOND

No visible cause and effect. Act first to stabilise, then move the situation to complex.

Practice: novel

- Checkout down on a Saturday morning (last month)

4 Clear

SENSE · CATEGORISE · RESPOND

Cause and effect are obvious to everyone.
Follow the agreed practice, but watch for complacency.

Practice: best practice · beware the cliff into chaos

- Deploy to staging
- Refunds for missing items
- Accessibility checks (WCAG AA)

5 Confused? Split It Up

THE CENTRE

When you can't tell which domain you're in, you're in confusion. People fall back on the approach they like best. Break the situation into parts and place each part in a domain.

Part 1: Stock data accuracy → complicated

Part 2: What customers will accept → complex

Part 3: Picking rules in store → clear

Part 4:

6 Our Approach

FOR THE SITUATION WE CHOSE

Situation: Will customers accept the substitutes we suggest when an item is missing?

Main domain: Complex

So we will: run small experiments, not a big design; learn from real orders before we scale up

Safe-to-fail experiments:
1. 200 customers approve substitutes
2. Show two choices instead of one
3. The picker phones the customer (one store)

Signs it's working: over 70% of substitutes accepted

Signs to stop: complaints rise or picking slows

Amplify or dampen by: widen to the whole region, or switch it off within a day

Revisit on: Friday 30 May

"Are we treating a complex problem as if it were only complicated?"

"What's the smallest safe-to-fail experiment we could run?"

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